by accident. Every time he cracked a joke, he forgot to take the microphone away from in front of his mouth. What happened to all that practice with the can of deodorant? It meant you could hear Gary giggling away to himself at his own jokes. He was as nervous as I'd been, but Gary was great. The whole day was.

Although we'd borrowed Peregrine's nanny for the night, Victoria and I took Brooklyn up to get him ready for bed. We went back downstairs and through into the tent where the party was going to carry on: there were cushions and pillows and drapes everywhere, this very oriental, kind of Indonesian, setting. The bride and groom, of course, had to have the first dance of the evening together, while people drifted through after the meal. Then, for a couple of hours, it was a chance to go round and say hello to everybody, catch up and have pictures taken before, at the stroke of midnight, everybody came outside for a big fireworks display. Which was amazing: even Victoria and I didn't know exactly what to expect. They were perfect: the spectacular treat to top off our perfect day.

I was so happy, so proud: content as I'd never been before in my life. Victoria and I were thrilled to be Mister and Missus. And when you're feeling like we were, you assume everybody else will be equally delighted. After all, in the world of soccer, managers are usually pleased to see their players marry and settle down. But during those first days and weeks after our wedding, it seemed I might be destined to be the exception that proved the rule.

Pre-season training was round the corner and, like any new husband, I was keen on a honeymoon. The first-team squad was split up anyway: most of the lads were off to Australia on tour, whereas the England contingent, who'd trained earlier in the summer on international duty, had a little extra time off. Maybe it was a mistake, but I asked if I could have a couple days more so that Victoria and I could spend a week abroad together. Actually, I didn't ask; my agent, Tony Stephens, did. He was seeing the United chairman, Martin Edwards, on business. They'd talked about the wedding and Tony mentioned that I'd love the couple of extra days to make going somewhere exotic worthwhile. We didn't fancy getting on a plane and then having to turn round at the other end to come straight back. Martin Edwards didn't think there'd be a problem with that but, when the manager got to hear about it, it sounded to him as if I'd tried to go behind his back. He wasn't best pleased and let me know about it. Never mind the blast on the phone, I had to settle for a whirlwind of a honeymoon and then report back– before the other England lads turned up and while the rest of the first team were on the other side of the world—to train with the reserves.